

EYEWITNESS March 1859

Slave Auction

Throughout the South, slave auctions supplied the demand for slave labor, especially among plantation owners. Black Americans were questioned, examined, and bid for in large auctions. Buyers often bought slaves without regard to family ties, dividing husbands, wives, mothers, and children. Usually, separations were permanent and slaves would never see their loved ones again.

“The buyers were generally of a rough breed, slangy, profane, and bearish, being for the most part, from the back river and swamp plantations, where the elegancies of polite life are not perhaps developed to the fullest extent ... how many aching hearts have been divorced by this summary proceeding, no man can ever know ... the negroes were examined with as little consideration as if they had been brutes indeed; the buyers pulling their mouths open to see their teeth, pinching their limbs to find how muscular they were, walking them up and down to detect any signs of lameness ... all of these humiliations were submitted to without a murmur ... the expression on the faces of all who stepped on the block was always the same, and told of more anguish than it is in the power of words to express. Blighted homes, crushed hopes and broken hearts was the sad story to be read in all the anxious faces. Some of them regarded the sale with perfect indifference, never making a motion save to turn from one side to the other at the word of the dapper Mr. Bryan, that all the crowd might have a fair view of their proportions, and then, when the sale was accomplished, stepping down from the block without caring to cast a look at the buyer, who now held all their happiness in his hands. Others, again, strained their eyes with eager glances from one buyer to another as the bidding went on, trying with earnest to follow the rapid voice of the auctioneer. Sometimes, two persons only would be bidding for the same chattel, all the other having resigned the contest, and then the poor creature on the block, conceiving an instantaneous preference for one of the buyers over the other, would regard the rivalry with the intensest interest ... settling down into a look of hopeless despair if the other won the victory.”